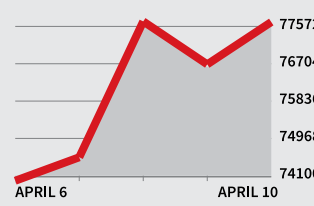


the hindu businessline

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IN FOCUS

	Week's close	Week's change
Nifty 50	24050.60	+1337.50
P/E Ratio (Sensex)	21.31	+1.16
US Dollar (in ₹)	92.72	-0.38
Gold Std 10 gm (in ₹)	149725.00	+3704
Silver 1 kg (in ₹)	239934.00	+12121



CORPORATE FILE.

TVS Motor overtakes Yamaha globally, narrows domestic gaps, driven by premiumisation, exports and EV growth **p7**

CLEANTECH.

PFBR milestone fuels thorium hopes, but scale-up timelines and challenges remain significant **p6**

Draft CAFE-3 norms: Govt eases penalties, shifts to carbon credits

SWAP TO SAVE. Auto-makers exceeding targets can trade surplus credits with those falling short

S Ronendra Singh
New Delhi

The government has proposed a more flexible compliance framework under the draft Corporate Average Fuel Efficiency-3 (CAFE-3) norms, easing penalties and allowing automakers to trade carbon credits to meet emission targets, sources told *businessline*.

The revised framework shifts the focus away from the earlier small-car versus large-vehicle debate and instead prioritises reducing overall fleet emissions.

The objective is to push original equipment manufacturers (OEMs) to produce vehicles with lower CO₂ emissions while accelerating adoption of electric vehicles (EVs), hybrids, and alternative fuels such as biofuels, in line with India's net-zero target for 2070.

The five-year plan for CAFE-3 norms will kick in from April 2027 and will cover the financial years 2027-28 to 2031-32.

KEY FEATURE

A key feature of the draft norms is the introduction of

Clean transition

Parameter	CAFE-2 norms	Draft CAFE-3 norms
Implementation period	FY23 to FY27	FY28 to FY32
Fuel consumption targets	Set progressive CO ₂ reduction targets based on vehicle weights	Introduces tighter fuel consumption limits with revised annual constants
Compliance flexibility	Limited flexibility for compliance, with no defined rule in place	Expands flexibility through credit trading, manufacturer pooling and credit purchases
Incentive for low-carbon technologies	Provided super credits for EVs and hybrids, and limited CO ₂ -reducing technologies allowed	Adds incentives like carbon neutrality factor for ethanol, CNG and hybrids, more tech credits and higher super credit multipliers for EVs, plug-in hybrids

a market-based compliance mechanism.

Automakers that exceed emission reduction targets will be allowed to trade surplus carbon credits with manufacturers that fall short, subject to mutually-agreed terms.

Under the draft, the outcome of such credit trading must be completed and reported to the designated agency responsible for monitoring compliance.

For instance, manufacturers that overachieve emission targets could monetise

surplus credits by transferring them to companies struggling to meet prescribed limits, thereby reducing compliance costs across the industry. The move signals a shift toward flexibility-driven regulation, aimed at securing industry buy-in while maintaining pressure on manufacturers to progressively reduce fleet emissions.

When calculating the weighted average CO₂ of an OEM, clean vehicles such as EVs, hybrids, plug-in hybrids, flex-fuel or flex-fuel

hybrid vehicles, are assigned higher weightage. When a lower CO₂ car is given higher weightage, it helps reduce the overall weighted average CO₂ of an OEM, thereby benefiting the OEM.

As per the draft, OEMs are permitted to offset any debit balance accumulated in their passbooks through the purchase of credits from the Bureau of Energy Efficiency.

"The price per gram of CO₂/km of such credits shall be as prescribed for each reporting period — FY28 — ₹2,500; FY29 — ₹3,000; FY30 — ₹3,500; FY31 — ₹4,000; and FY32 — ₹4,500," it stated.

For performance assessment, the annual average of actual fuel consumption for each OEM would be calculated on the modified Indian driving cycle, a laboratory-based chassis dynamometer test cycle used to certify fuel efficiency and emissions for passenger vehicles, similar to the new European driving cycle.

"The government has addressed the automobile industry's grievances, shifting focus from penalising manufacturers to incentivising a greener transition," said an automobile expert.

Tiger Global reassessment back on table

Shishir Sinha
New Delhi

With the Supreme Court ruling against Tiger Global clearing the way for tax recovery, the Income Tax Department is set to resume reassessment proceedings against the US-based fund, signalling that the recent General Anti-Avoidance Rule (GAAR) amendments do not dilute the impact of the judgment.

Tax officials said the March 31 notification issued by the Central Board of Direct Taxes, which protects legacy investments made before April 1, 2017, from the ambit of the GAAR, does not alter the position in the Tiger Global case.

GAAR empowers tax authorities to deny tax benefits arising from arrangements primarily designed to avoid taxes, even if they comply with the letter of the law.

"The notification is not about any specific case. Since the Supreme Court has ruled in favour of the department in the Tiger Global case, proceedings will continue as per law," a senior official said, adding that reassessment is expected to be completed soon.

Read more on p10

TCS to evolve beyond IT services, says Krithivasan

Vallari Sanzgiri
Thomas K Thomas
Mumbai

Tata Consultancy Services' (TCS) identity as an IT services firm is set to evolve, with CEO and Managing Director K Krithivasan indicating a shift away from programming-heavy work towards AI-led roles and services.

In an interview with *businessline*, Krithivasan said, "We will need fewer programmers. We require model trainers, context/prompt engineers, people who can test models and agent developers."

In terms of jobs, he stated that economic activity will increase manifold with every technological disruption, and create more jobs. In FY26, the company offered almost 44,000 campus offers, the largest ever by a private sector in a single year. For FY27, TCS has rolled out around 25,000 campus offers.

Replying to Anthropic's view that IT services firms are irrelevant, Krithivasan said in the short term, companies like TCS will be relevant as clients are still not sure how to use AI.

He spoke of the need for system integrators like TCS that understand the required context and technology im-



We will need fewer programmers. We require model trainers, prompt engineers, model testers and agent developers

K KRITHIVASAN
CEO and Managing Director
Tata Consultancy Services



plementation to provide the business benefits of AI.

"Things could change in the future, but we are ready for it," he said, adding that the company is cannibalising its own revenue in terms of software engineering to provide benefits in addressing backlog issues.

DATA CENTRE TIMELINE

Beyond IT services, TCS' HyperVault data centre is expected to go live in 2028. When asked about the significant time gap from the time of the data centre's announcement, Krithivasan said, "it takes 12 to 18 months from the time you put the shovel in the ground to operationalisation. A twelve- to 18-month period is still quite accelerated."

The tech giant already has two MoUs for the data centre

with ongoing conversations for a few more. Currently, TCS is finalising the design, Service Level Agreement, land, and other timelines after which it will start looking at putting actual money into these investments.

"Currently, our target is 1 GW, but as it scales up, we will recalibrate," said Krithivasan.

FY27 OUTLOOK

Despite headwinds in FY26, the company remains optimistic about the next financial year, citing a healthy order book, strong customer spends and the larger move towards tech modernisation.

"Definitely, we are more optimistic. I think some of the headwinds are behind us. So, that's the opportunity," said Krithivasan.

Interview on p3

'Pakistan accessed strategic Indian data via Chinese CCTVs'

Dalip Singh
New Delhi

In a move reminiscent of high-level Israeli espionage, Pakistan's ISI reportedly orchestrated a covert operation using compromised Chinese-made CCTV systems. By infiltrating cameras positioned

near strategic Indian assets in border States and Union Territories, the Pakistani spy agency was able to monitor military movements and equipment logistics in real time.

For nearly three months, the ISI was getting live visual feeds and information from

key strategic defence sites and central armed police forces installations across Punjab, Haryana, Rajasthan and Jammu and Kashmir through solar-powered SIM-enabled devices linked to EseeCloud — a Chinese surveillance equipment — senior Delhi Police officials told

businessline. EseeCloud, developed by Guangzhou Juan Intelligent Tech Joint Stock in China, was allegedly transmitting live footage to data centres in China, from where the information was further relayed to handlers in Pakistan

Also read p2

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MONDAY SPECIALS.

SPARK
The chatter-bots speaking up for India



In India, the next wave of AI may largely be a chatty affair. As businesses race to replace call centres with intelligent voice agents, start-ups are building for a uniquely complex market where scale, language and latency (the delay between input and output) collide. According to Tracxn data, Indian voice AI start-ups raised \$160.58 million across 37 funding rounds between 2019 and 2026. Funding peaked in 2023 at \$41.6 million across five rounds. **p8**

CURRENT ACCOUNT
India credit funds shrug off US blues

Last month, investors attempting to redeem holdings from Blue Owl Capital — a niche American alternative investment firm — were met with unexpected caps on withdrawals. The move was echoed by industry giants like BlackRock, Apollo and KKR, limiting outflows from their private credit funds. This wave of restrictions sent chills through the \$3.5 trillion global private credit market, a sector that has boomed since the 2008 financial crisis. **p9**

QUICKLY.

Juno Joule starts work on CBG plant in Telangana

Hyderabad: Juno Joule Bio Fuels commenced construction of its flagship compressed biogas (CBG) project at Narmetta, Siddipet district, Telangana. Ground-breaking was performed on Sunday. The project is a part of a larger cluster development comprising 10 CBG plants, each with a 10 tonne per day capacity, aggregating 100 TPD, with a total planned investment of ₹700 crore. **OUR BUREAU**

AIG Hospitals joins ICMR for digital health push

Hyderabad: AIG Hospitals has entered into a Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) with the Indian Council of Medical Research (ICMR) for accelerating innovation in digital health, healthcare management, and translational medicine. By combining its strengths in patient care and translational research with ICMR's leadership in national health research, AIG Hospitals will create solutions that are scalable and impactful, said D Nageshwar Reddy, Chairman, AIG Hospitals. **OUR BUREAU**

‘China got live info on India’s strategic assets from CCTVs, relayed it to Pak’

SYSTEM BREACH. ISI was getting live visual feeds and information from Chinese CCTVs installed at key sites

Dalip Singh
New Delhi

In a move reminiscent of high-level Israeli espionage, Pakistan's ISI reportedly orchestrated a covert operation using compromised Chinese-made CCTV systems. By infiltrating cameras positioned near strategic Indian assets in border States and Union Territories, the Pakistani spy agency was able to monitor military movements and equipment logistics in real time.

LIVE VISUAL FEEDS
For nearly three months, the ISI was getting live visual feeds and information from key strategic defence sites and central armed police forces (CAPFs) installations across Punjab, Haryana, Rajasthan and Jammu and Kashmir through nine solar-powered SIM-enabled devices linked to EseeCloud — a widely used Chinese software platform for CCTV



DRAGON EYE. EseeCloud, developed by Guangzhou Juan Intelligent Tech Joint Stock Co Ltd in China, was allegedly transmitting live footage to data centres in China

and surveillance equipment, senior Delhi police officials told *businessline*. EseeCloud, developed by Guangzhou Juan Intelligent Tech Joint Stock Co Ltd in China, was allegedly transmitting live footage to data centres in China and from where the information was further relayed to handlers in Pakistan. These findings have emerged from ongoing investigations of Delhi police

special cell which on Friday busted an espionage module of ISI and Babbar Khalsa International (BKI) after arresting six persons from Punjab and Delhi.

SENSITIVE LOCATIONS
The sleuths have recovered nine CCTV cameras of EseeCloud installed near sensitive security and defence establishments in States and UTs close to the Pakistan border.

Alarmed at the unravelling of the espionage plot, police sources said the armed forces should carry out a security audit of their strategic assets to check vulnerability arising out of installed Chinese CCTV cameras inside and outside their premises to plug possible risks to national security. Sanjeev Sehgal, Founder and MD of Sparsh CCTV and Convener of the Video Surveillance Committee at Bureau of Indian Standards (BIS), told *businessline* that the introduction of STQC Essential Requirements is a landmark step to secure CCTV networks against vulnerabilities.

GAME PLAN
The Pakistan intelligence game plan was to gather the sensitive information through regular round-the-clock monitoring of movement of men and machines and target them in case of another war with India, sources elaborated.

An ISI handler by the code name of Captain Rana was supervising the Indian module. It is learnt that they used the terror network of the BKI for manpower resources management and used sleeper cells across Spain, Germany and Dubai for fixing EseeCloud-made CCTV cameras on locations assigned by the ISI for spying. The CCTV cameras installations were done under the garb of keeping an eye on truck movement in a transportation business and the ring leader for this assignment was a Dubai-based Indian operator, informed police sources. “These locations included Kapurthala, Jalandhar, Pathankot, Patiala and Moga in Punjab, as well as Ambala in Haryana, Kathua in Jammu and Kashmir, and Bikaner and Alwar in Rajasthan,” Additional Commissioner of Police (Special Cell) Pramod Singh Kushwah told reporters on Friday.

PM pushes for women’s reservation ahead of 2029 general elections

Our Bureau
New Delhi



Prime Minister Narendra Modi

Prime Minister Narendra Modi has reached out to floor leaders of Lok Sabha and Rajya Sabha for support, saying that it is imperative to hold 2029 Lok Sabha and assembly elections with women reservation in place. Ahead of the three-day special session of Parliament from April 16 to 18, Modi wrote to opposition leaders saying that it is essential that women play a greater, active role if India has to realise its vision of becoming a developed nation.

EXTENSIVE DISCUSSION
“After extensive deliberations, we have reached the conclusion that the time has now come to implement the Nari Shakti Vandan Adhinyam in its true spirit across the country. It is imperative that the 2029 Lok Sabha elections and Assembly elections are conducted with women’s reservation in place,” the Prime Minister’s letter read. The proposed amendments to the Women’s Reservation Act will multiply the number of Lok Sabha seats to 816, with 273 reserved for women.

The provision to provide 33 per cent reservation to women in the Lok Sabha and State assemblies was enabled by amending the Constitution in 2023. Earlier, the government wanted to complete the delimitation exercise on the basis of the Census 2027 before pushing for women’s quota in parliament and assemblies. As per that strategy, reservation would not have been enforceable before 2034. Modi, however, appealed to all parties to “demonstrate responsibility towards women and future genera-

tions” with the implementation of the Women’s Reservation Bill. “I am writing this letter so that we may all come together in one voice to pass this amendment. It would be great to have many Members of Parliament express their views on this subject in Parliament. This is a moment above any one party or individual. It is a moment to demonstrate responsibility towards women and our future generations,” PM said. He also stated that this special sitting is an opportunity to further strengthen democracy. It is also a moment to reiterate our collective commitment to moving forward together, taking everyone along. Modi said today, everyone is witnessing the increasing participation of women in various spheres of public life.

CONGRESS’ RESPONSE
The Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge responded that it would be “impossible” to have any useful discussion on the women’s quota law without details of delimitation and other aspects, and demanded that an all-party meeting be called on the matter after the current round of State polls gets over on April 29.

Wipro to report muted Q4 on tight margins, lower growth

Sanjana B
Bengaluru

Wipro is set to announce its financial results for Q4FY26 on April 16. The company is expected to signal a muted start to FY27, with June-quarter IT services revenue guidance likely ranging from a 1.5 per cent decline to marginal 0.5 per cent growth sequentially in cc terms, as delays in deal ramp-ups weigh on performance. According to a brokerage poll, the company’s global

IT revenue is estimated at ₹22,445–24,397 crore in Q4, implying growth of -0.8 per cent to 3.6 per cent QoQ (cc) and -1.2 per cent to 0.4 per cent YoY (cc). Profit after tax (PAT) is projected at ₹3,569–3,791 crore, up 17.6 per cent -21.6 q-o-q and 2.7 per cent -6.2 per cent y-o-y. Brokerages expect Q1 revenue growth of -1.5 per cent to +0.5 per cent q-o-q (cc), weighed down by delayed deal ramp-ups, potential share losses, and pricing pressure. Overall revenue growth will include

around 160 bps contribution from the DTS acquisition. **EBIT MARGINS**
IT services EBIT margins are likely to contract by around 50 bps q-o-q to around 16 per cent, due to DTS-related dilution, possible wage hikes, and slower growth momentum. “Recurring IT Services EBIT margins are expected to dip 35 bps q-o-q given wage hikes, effective March 1, 2026, large deal ramp up cost and full quarter consol-



Overall revenue growth will include around 160 bps contribution from the DTS acquisition

to remain broadly in line with previous quarters, with a limited ramp-up in a few mega deals during Q4. Order intake, especially large deals, is likely to stay healthy, supported by Wipro’s continued aggressive deal pursuit. According to a MOFSL report, BFSI and healthcare are expected to remain stable, while consumer and EMR may stay under pressure due to tariff uncertainty and delayed decision-making. Slower ramp-up of some large deals is also weighing on growth.

Equirus Capital report. Similarly, a JM Financial Institutional Securities noted that headwinds include wage hikes and around 40 bps impact from acquisitions. Deal TCV is expected

idation of low margin business Harman DTS M&A, effective early December 2025, which will be partly compensated by tailwinds from currency and cost efficiencies,” observed an

Retail investors give recent IPOs a miss due to weak listing gains

Suresh P Iyengar
Mumbai

Retail investors have given recent initial public offerings the cold shoulder on lack of bumper listing gains amid bearish market sentiments and high minimum investment threshold. In this backdrop, the retail portion, in 10 out of the 18 IPOs that have hit the market so far this year, have remained under-subscribed. The unsubscribed portion is usually reallocated to the qualified institutional buyers or non-institutional investors.

RETAIL SUBSCRIPTION
Interestingly, the retail segment’s decision to stay away from some of these IPOs is justified as many of these stocks now trade below the issue price. In this month alone, IPOs

of Powerica Ltd and Sai Parenterals, which cumulatively raised ₹834 crore, have managed to get only 10 per cent of their retail portion subscribed. While Amir Chand Jagdish Kumar Exports received 1.4 times retail subscription, it is now available at 41 per cent discount to the issue price of ₹212 per share. It closed at ₹125 a piece on Friday. Similarly, Innovision Ltd, which raised ₹311 crore last month by issuing shares at ₹519 a piece, traded at 40 per cent discount to close at ₹312 on Friday. Its retail portion was subscribed only 60 per cent. Gaurav Bhandari, CEO, Monarch Network Capital said the waning retail interest in IPOs is not a sign of weakness; it is a sign of maturity as they have evolved significantly over the past five years and do not eye listing-day gains alone. The problem also lies with

valuation of companies which treat IPOs as an exit option for promoters and private equity rather than an opportunity to create long-term wealth for public shareholders, he said. **PIPELINE TO SLOW**
The demand to reduce the minimum investment level also deserves consideration as the current ₹2 lakh cap for retail investors limits participation, especially in large IPOs where the lot size itself becomes a barrier, said Bhandari. Narinder Wadhwa, MD and CEO, Ski Capital Services said, “We expect the IPO pipeline to slow in the near term, with companies likely to defer listings until conditions improve. A revival in IPO momentum will depend on overall market stability, supported by stable crude oil prices, a steady rupee, and a meaningful return of FII inflows,” he added.

Centre not taking away State’s power on bonus price for agri produce, clarifies FM

Shishir Sinha
New Delhi

Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman categorically stated that the Centre is not seizing States’ powers on setting agricultural bonuses. The Finance Ministry, in the meantime, clarified that the Expenditure Department’s recent letter regarding the alignment of bonus policies with national interests serves as a non-binding advisory meant to streamline State policies with national goals. In a social media post, Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman dismissed Tamil Nadu Chief Minister MK Stalin’s allegations that the Union Government ordered the State to stop paddy cultivation incentives as “factually baseless,



Union Minister Nirmala Sitharaman

politically motivated and a deliberate distortion” and intended to mislead farmers. Addressing a public meeting in Thanjavur, he said, “I have shocking news to share with you. Just as I returned to Chennai after campaigning in Srikazhi, Cuddalore and Villupuram, officials showed me the letter asking us to reconsider providing the incentive (given over and above the Minimum Support Price fixed by the Centre). Can

anyone even think of this? The letter has come from the Finance Ministry headed by Nirmala Sitharaman, who claims to be from Tamil Nadu. Will AI-ADMK general secretary Edappadi K Palaniswami come forward to condemn the BJP at least for this?” Stalin asked. **‘ADVISORY ONLY’**
The communication in question is a letter by the Expenditure Secretary, dated January 1, 2026, to the Chief Secretaries of States to align their bonus policy to promote pulses, oilseeds and millets, in line with the national priorities for nutritional security, *Aatmanirbharta* (self-reliance) and sustainable agriculture. “The letter was an advisory to States and was not a directive,” the Finance Ministry said in a statement.

Adding to this, Sitharaman said that Centre’s suggestion to States was rooted in a positive, forward-looking vision for encouraging crop diversification and attaining self-sufficiency in crops such as pulses, oilseeds, etc so that farmers can tap into better price realisation by cultivating crops where domestic demand far outstrips supply. The declaration of a bonus over and above the Minimum Support Price (MSP) has been, and remains, entirely the prerogative of State Governments. “No one has taken that power away,” she said. The Ministry highlighted that Centre has also consistently aligned MSP increases in favour of pulses and oilseeds to encourage farmers to shift away from over-concentration in a few crops.

‘AI to reduce uncertainties and expand opportunities’

Our Bureau
Chennai

The emerging role of AI in the financial ecosystem should reduce uncertainties and expand opportunities for all stakeholders to advance inclusion, maximise efficiency and strengthen trust” said J Swaminathan, Deputy Governor of Reserve Bank of India. Delivering the 20th CUB V Narayanan Memorial Lecture at SASTRA Campus in Thanjavur, the DG of RBI laid down a five-point charter guideline for full scale AI adoption in the Financial & Banking industry.

GUIDELINES
These include human responsibility, fairness and explainability, strong data governance, institutional adoption maturity and inclusivity by design. These five points ensure fair outcomes, transparency, humane approach, democratisation and risk prevention said the DG. Speaking on the topic “AI in Finance - What can Change and what should not” the Deputy Governor shared valuable insights on customer & data sensitivities, non-isolation of small borrowers & malicious automation besides highlighting the need for human responsibility & accountability for AI assisted decisions. “Financial decision making cannot be a back box theory and it requires tremendous institutional responsibility,” said a release quoting Swaminathan.

As imports grow, India pushes forward to diversify its LPG supplier base

Rishi Ranjan Kala
New Delhi



SUPPLY GAP. As per industry sources, India consumes around 80,000 tonnes per day of LPG and imports around 54,000 tpd

As LPG imports continue to grow, India is moving to diversify its import basket. The country is likely to import around 20.82 million tonnes (mt) of liquefied petroleum gas (LPG) in FY27 as the world’s third largest consumer procures more than 60 per cent of its domestic consumption. The Petroleum Planning & Analysis Cell (PPAC) expects India to consume around 34.69 mt of LPG in FY27, a growth of roughly 4.5 per cent on an annual basis. The cumulative LPG consumption rose by 6 per cent y-o-y to 33.21 mt in FY26 provisionally, which is the highest annual growth in us-

age since FY19. There are 33.37 crore households using the cooking fuel, including roughly 10.55 crore PM Ujjwala Yojana (PMUY) beneficiaries. In FY26, imports stood at 20.50 mt during April-February, accounting for 61.73 per cent of the total consumption. Similarly, India imported almost 66 per cent of its LPG

demand (20.67 mt) in FY25 out of the cumulative consumption of 31.33 mt. In FY24, imports accounted for around 60.40 per cent (18.51 mt) of the total consumption (29.66 mt). As per industry sources, India generally consumes around 80,000 tonnes per day (TPD) of LPG and imports around 54,000 TPD. The conflict in West Asia has severely impacted In-

dia’s LPG supplies considering that around 90 per cent of the imports, or roughly 60 per cent of the domestic consumption, comes from the Middle East Gulf region. As per Vortexa, MEG (excluding Iran) is India’s largest supplier of LPG, covering 92 per cent of the country’s imports as of 2025. **LPG CARGOES**
India has also been trying to diversify its import basket. For instance, it has increased its LPG importing sources from 10 to 15. Since the closure of the Hormuz, India has been trying to arrange LPG supplies from the US, Russia, Australia, Saudi Arabia, the UAE and Iran. Procuring the commodity from the US requires around 45 days of travel time.

Aligning WACR with repo rate is linked to level of liquidity: RBI study

Our Bureau
Mumbai

Keeping the weighted average call rate (WACR) aligned to the repo rate entails different levels of liquidity in deficit and surplus conditions, according to a RBI study. Moreover, the extent of alignment is also contingent on the level of the surplus/deficit. The findings of an RBI study on “Optimal Level of Liquidity” suggest that surplus liquidity in the range of 0.6 to 1.1 per cent of NDTL (net demand and time liabilities) or deposits is likely to keep the WACR between 5 to 10 basis points (bps) below the repo rate (currently at 5.25 per cent). So, in absolute terms, surplus liquidity should be in the ₹1.53 lakh crore to ₹2.80 lakh crore range, going by the

NDTL of scheduled banks as on March 30, 2026. This will keep the WACR between 5.20-5.15 per cent. **LIQUIDITY DEFICIT**
Liquidity deficit in the range of 0.4 to 0.7 per cent of NDTL is likely to keep the WACR 5 to 10 bps above the repo rate. In absolute terms, liquidity should be in the range of ₹1.02 lakh crore to ₹1.78 lakh crore. This will keep the WACR between 5.30-5.35 per cent. The guiding principle of RBI’s liquidity management is to align WACR (the operating target of the monetary policy) with the policy repo rate. Liquidity mismatches could lead to deviation of the operating target from the policy rate, hampering monetary policy transmission. Repo rate is the interest rate at which Banks’ borrows

funds from RBI to overcome short-term liquidity mismatches. Call money market is a market for uncollateralised lending and borrowing of funds. This market is predominantly overnight and is open for participation only to scheduled commercial banks and the primary dealers. **LIQUIDITY CONDITIONS**
The study noted that central banks actively manage liquidity conditions in the banking system to ensure that the operating target remains aligned to the policy rate, hovering within the interest rate corridor. RBI officials noted that excessive liquidity surplus over a prolonged period runs the risk of driving short term interest rates to ultra-low levels, distorting risk perceptions and engendering asset price bubbles.

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NEWS SNIPPETS.

Renewable energy ministry approves pilot CfD scheme

The Ministry of New and Renewable Energy (MNRE) has approved a pilot Contracts for Difference (CfD) scheme, to be implemented



by Solar Energy Corporation of India (SECI) for 500 MW/1,500 MWh, focused on non-solar hours.

A CfD is a two-sided price hedge: the renewable generator is paid the difference when market prices fall below a pre-agreed strike price, and pays back when prices exceed it.

India's version is tailored to solve a specific problem — the evening peak. "By targeting the three non-solar hours, MNRE's new CfD guidelines directly address India's evening peak and indirectly encourage pairing of solar with BESS for flexible dispatch," notes Vinay Pabba, CEO, Vibrant Energy.

Some design choices are worth noting. The 12-year tenor is shorter than the global norm of 15–20 years. This could push up bid prices, as developers price in uncertainty beyond the contract period. If CfDs are to scale up meaningfully in India, a longer tenor may be necessary.

The plan envisages a ₹76-crore stabilisation fund. This is "fiscally conservative and politically intelligent," says Pabba, while also pointing out that by capping the government's risk to ₹76 crore and passing on the excess risk of the pool losses to SECI, bankability can get diluted for generators.

The mandated bidding sequence — "Green Day Ahead Market" to "Day Ahead Market" to Real Time Market — is a strong intervention. It prioritises green market participation, reduces volumes, and could minimise disputes around curtailment and non-clearance.

Less orthodox is the 30:70 sharing of gains and losses between the generator and the CfD pool. In classic CfDs, generators face the full upside and downside relative to the strike price. Diluting this linkage may weaken price signals and reduce incentives for optimal market behaviour. Similarly, the requirement that renewable energy certificate revenues from brown market sales should be credited to the pool strengthens the scheme's finances, but removes a potential upside for developers — again likely to be reflected in higher bids.

Overall, the pilot is less about adding megawatts and more about integrating renewables into the grid — specifically to meet demand when solar is unavailable. That is where India's next energy challenge lies.

Green India mission limps

The government runs two key initiatives under the National Mission for a Green India: Green India Mission, aimed at protecting, restoring and enhancing India's forest cover;



and forest fire prevention and management. Yet the Ministry for Environment, Forests and Climate Change has not been able to spend the money allocated to

it. A parliamentary standing committee that went into the financial demands of the ministry has noted that Budget 2025-26 had allocated ₹220 crore to the mission and this was reduced to ₹95.7 crore at the 'revised estimates' stage — 44 per cent of the initial allocation. The ministry admitted to the committee that the reduced allocation "slows afforestation and eco-restoration activities, reduces the area of degraded forests taken up for treatment, delays new landscape-based interventions and constrains support to Joint Forest Management Committees (JFMCs), capacity building, micro-planning, and livelihood activities linked to non-timber forest produce (NTFP) and eco enterprises". However, the ministry could not spend even the reduced allocation. Till end-January this year, it had spent only ₹49.95 crore, or 43 per cent of the reduced revised allocation. The committee has asked the ministry to "examine the slow progress of funds utilisation".

REALITY CHECK

Despite PFBR going critical, India is still a long way from thorium utilisation

NOT SO FAST. There are several significant hurdles that could potentially delay the country's date with nuclear-led energy security

M Ramesh

The deliriously joyful reaction of the social media commentariat to the news of the 500 MWe prototype fast-breeder reactor (PFBR) going critical is not without basis. It is certainly a significant milestone in India's energy history. However, it is useful to temper the frenzy with some hard facts.

Indeed, PFBR paves the way for India to use thorium for energy production. India has a fourth of the world's thorium reserves. Estimates vary — from the most optimistic 1.07 million tonnes (according to the government) to 518,000 "extractable" tonnes (according to Bhabha Atomic Research Centre).

Now, here is a telling data: a tonne of thorium (after it is converted into nuclear fuel uranium-233) can — conservatively speaking — provide as much energy as 3 million tonnes of coal. So, even at BARC's estimate, India is sitting on thorium resources equivalent to 1.3–1.5 trillion tonnes of coal, which is a little more than all the coal reserves discovered in the world till today.

What this means is, long after West Asia has run out of oil, India could be lounging on the energy throne, producing clean, cheap power.

Social media has intuited this promise — that explains the delirium.

THE IFS AND BUTS

For sure, nuclear energy powered by a fleet of breeder reactors will play a big part in India's quest for 'net zero' by 2070.

However, there are two points of note in all this. The first is that a commercial thorium reactor is likely three to four decades away.



ATOMIC OPTION. The prototype fast-breeder reactor at Kalpakkam, which went critical recently, paving the way for thorium use in energy production

India took 22 years to build the PFBR. While the next fast-breeder reactors may not take as much time from start to finish, the start line is still at least a decade away.

After all, the PFBR is still a demonstrator. As Dr Anil Kakodkar, India's pre-eminent nuclear scientist and former chairman of Atomic Energy Commission, put it, you have to "do to learn". Learning on the hoof is inherently riddled with surprises. The PFBR needs to be stabilised first. It will take 12-18 months to start pumping electricity into the grid, but those running the plant would still need to observe

and absorb operational nuances, which is time-consuming.

Secondly, the first few reactors are likely to be more oriented towards producing (breeding) plutonium-239 rather than converting thorium into U-233.

Theoretically both can be done simultaneously, but there is a trade-off, as U-233 production will reduce Pu-239 breeding. The need is to first build enough stocks of Pu-239 before starting in-situ production of U-233.

So even after the first few breeder reactors come up — after over a decade, if done quickly —

getting into the thorium cycle is farther away. By then, there is a distinct possibility that nuclear fusion may have emerged as a better alternative — investors are already betting on it.

Moreover, we cannot really get carried away by the fact that India is only the third country — after Russia and China — to have a fast-breeder reactor. Russia, with two operating reactors — BN 600 and BN 800 — and another under construction (BN 1200) is a master in this technology; China is only slightly ahead of India.

It is not as if India succeeded

where other countries failed. France, Japan and the US dabbled in breeder reactors but gave up, not because they could not do it but realised they did not need it.

You don't need to break your head over hard-to-build, difficult-to-run breeder reactors if you have enough uranium, though Russia has chosen to do that.

India went down this path because it has thorium; breeders are the quickest route to get to it.

Building an indigenous breeder reactor is creditable, but not evidence that India has succeeded where others failed.

WAFER-THIN SUFFICIENCY

Renewable components supply chained to imports

K Bharat Kumar

Despite the gains made in the manufacture of renewable energy modules, India continues to be dependent on supply chains that originate elsewhere, especially China. The Energy Technology Perspective 2026, released by the International Energy Agency, says that though India is almost fully self-sufficient in the assembling of equipment, it is dependent on imports for components such as wafers and polysilicon, which are used in the manufacture of solar panels.

The risks are obvious. The report hypothesises that a one-month halt in Chinese export of solar supply-chain components would cause an output loss of \$1 billion at module production plants

across the world, of which 40 per cent would be felt in India and Southeast Asia.

Specifically, wafer production is almost entirely concentrated in China — over 90 per cent global share — and any disruption would impact India's module output in the absence of alternative comparable global suppliers.

China's investments in the sector over the past few decades are showing up India in stark contrast when it comes to cost-competitiveness. Domestic solar photovoltaic module prices are currently at about \$0.15/W, compared with China's \$0.09/W. Similarly, in the wind sector, domestic component costs are 20-25 per cent higher than imports, primarily due to the high cost of raw materials and expensive financing.

While India's import duties and concessional custom



SUM OF PARTS. China manufactures 90 per cent of the wafers used globally in the production of solar panels BLOOMBERG

duty certificates help protect domestic firms, they also increase costs for end-consumers, the IEA says.

PLUSES AND MINUSES

India's infrastructure bottlenecks and high logistics costs

find mention in the report. In the wind energy industry, while assembly-level local content is high, the manufacture of sub-components is limited in scale and capability, particularly for new, larger turbine models.

However, it's not all gloom. The report also highlights India's achievements in adding renewable energy capacity. Especially in financial year 2025-26, the country's capacity additions in renewable energy were noteworthy.

Government data show that installed solar power capacity crossed the 150 GW mark. March alone witnessed a record 6.65 GW additions. In wind power, too, India installed a record 6.05 GW capacity — the highest ever — surpassing the 2016-17 record of 5.2 GW.

The IEA points out that in the solar PV sector, India is expected to witness the largest increase in global production share among all regions, from 3 per cent in 2024 to more than 10 per cent by 2035. Between 2022 and 2024, module and cell manufacturing capacity ex-

panded threefold, and the country is expected to achieve a module trade surplus this year. By 2030, India is projected to add 70 GW of module capacity and reach near self-sufficiency in both module and cell production. India is also expanding into difficult upstream segments — wafer manufacturing capacity is projected to reach over 65 GW by 2030, while polysilicon capacity — which was zero in 2024 — is expected to rise to 25 GW.

Similarly, the wind energy sector is experiencing growing levels of indigenisation. Under the revised policies introduced in April 2025, local sourcing of blades, towers, gearboxes, and generators is mandatory for all new wind projects. The government aims to raise the share of local content from 64 per cent to 85 per cent by 2030 to ensure self-reliance.

Oil-starved industry looks to reignite heat pumps

How clusters producing similar goods are well suited to tap steam energy viably, backed by solar power

Joydeep Gupta

The two-week truce between the US and Iran, along with the promise to reopen the Strait of Hormuz, seemingly offered a measure of relief. Yet, oil and gas supplies appear unlikely to return to pre-war levels anytime soon. In India, while the plight of households struggling to afford cooking gas has drawn attention, the distress in industry — especially micro, small and medium enterprises (MSMEs) — has gone largely under-reported. Many units have been forced to cut production by half or more.

While India has a long-term commitment to clean energy, the West Asia conflict has underscored the urgency of interim solutions. Experts, think tanks, and industry stakeholders have begun exploring alternatives such as electric heat pumps and other emerging technologies,

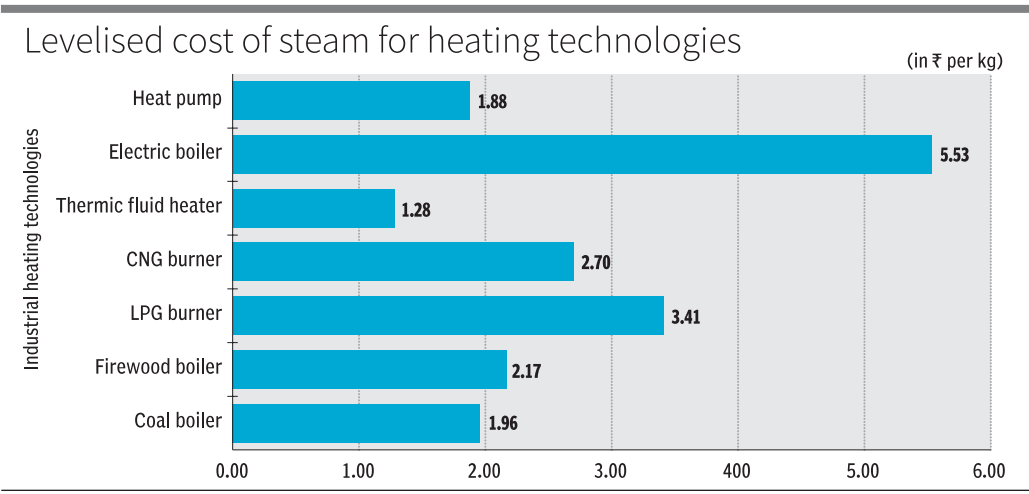
particularly in MSME clusters.

Heat pumps are based on well-established technology but have historically seen limited adoption in industry due to higher costs compared to oil or gas. That equation is now shifting.

Concerns over fuel availability and price volatility are making heat pumps increasingly competitive, especially when deployed at the scale of industrial clusters.

Industrial heat requirements vary widely depending on the product, process, and scale, ruling out a one-size-fits-all solution. However, experts from industry bodies, venture capital groups, and philanthropies suggest that heat pumps are well-suited for clusters producing similar goods — such as glass units in Firozabad or leather units in Chennai — where low to medium temperature heat is sufficient.

While heat pumps can run on grid electricity, their environmental advantage depends on



the source of power. If the grid remains fossil fuel-heavy, the benefits are limited. To address this, experts point to the feasibility of large-scale rooftop solar installations in industrial clusters, potentially supplemented by concentrated solar power. These

can generate ample electricity for heat pumps during the day, with the grid acting as backup.

For higher temperature needs, thermal storage and hybrid systems may be required, though these will take time and sector-specific innovation. For now, the

immediate focus is on scaling up heat pump adoption.

COST-COMPETITIVENESS Industry representatives involved in the discussions note that rising and volatile energy costs are already pushing factory

owners to consider alternatives. Heat pumps provide low-cost energy (see table).

Investment decisions, however, will hinge on three factors: lifecycle cost-competitiveness rather than just upfront investment; reliability and compatibility with continuous industrial processes; and proven performance.

Pilot projects play a crucial role. MSME operators also stress the importance of minimal disruption to ongoing operations.

Three enabling conditions have been identified for scaling up heat pumps. First is financing. While capital availability is not seen as a major constraint — thanks in part to philanthropic guarantees that can de-risk investments — there is a need for viable models. One proposed approach is "heat-as-a-service", where heat is supplied under purchase agreements, reducing the burden of upfront investment.

Second is policy support from both central and State govern-

ments. While industry acknowledges the push towards electrification, it seeks greater clarity and stability. Tariff structures, open access to power, and alignment of incentives between fossil fuels and clean energy will be critical. A white paper outlining these issues is expected to be submitted to policymakers.

Third is grid readiness. Although capacity may appear adequate at a macro level, plant-level constraints and connection readiness could pose challenges. This calls for closer coordination with power system planning.

The immediate opportunity lies in identifying priority sectors and clusters, supporting early deployments, and building credible pathways to scale. These efforts must also align with a broader national roadmap for clean industrial heat, consistent with long-term energy transition goals.

The writer is India Programme Lead, Earth Journalism Network

OFFICE BUZZ.

Less engaged workforce

Globally employee engagement has dropped to 20 per cent from its peak of 23 per cent in 2022, finds Gallup's State of the Global



Workplace 2026 report. This is the first time global engagement has dropped for two consecutive years, says the report. The biggest drop was in South Asia (minus-5

points). No region of the world showed increased engagement in the past year. Last year, low engagement cost the world economy approximately \$10 trillion in lost productivity, or 9 per cent of GDP, it says.

In 2025, South Asia (primarily India) experienced an eight-point decline in manager engagement — the largest decline for any region, finds the report. At the same time, the percentage of managers in South Asia also declined, suggesting that employers are cutting management roles, it says.

“Some evidence suggests that in 2025, India's IT sector saw a substantial slowdown in hiring, along with cuts to mid-level and senior roles, possibly driven in part by AI adoption,” says the report, analysing the reduction in management roles.

Financial stress at work

A survey of 637 working professionals in the 30-45 age group in India, conducted by personal finance advisory firm 1 Finance, has



revealed widespread financial stress, which, it says, directly affects workplace productivity and job satisfaction across major metro cities. More than

two-thirds of respondents report that personal financial worries intrude on their work hours, while a comparable share have considered leaving otherwise satisfying roles purely for higher pay. Over half have lived without a meaningful savings buffer for extended periods.

From investing and retirement planning to basic budgeting, professionals appear to lack confidence in making financial decisions at multiple levels. This points to a systemic gap in financial preparedness, where even those earning well may feel unequipped to manage, grow, and sustain their money effectively, amplifying stress and uncertainty over time, notes the report.

● FULL THROTTLE

TVS Motor bikes into global third spot

PLAYBOOK UPGRADE. With premiumisation, TVS is gaining on Hero and Honda on home turf. But Japanese rivals continue to dominate

Amit Vijay Mohile

The global two-wheeler hierarchy has undergone a rare shift in CY2025, with TVS Motor Company overtaking Yamaha to become the third-largest manufacturer by volume, marking a milestone for India's auto industry. But the achievement also underscores a deeper structural gap: Collectively, Indian manufacturers continue to trail their Japanese rivals by over 10 million units annually.

Honda alone sells more than 20 million units globally, while Yamaha and Suzuki together outpace the combined volumes of India's 'Big Three' — Hero MotoCorp, TVS Motor, and Bajaj Auto. For TVS, the more immediate challenge lies closer home, where it trails Hero and Honda in the domestic market.

CLOSING THE GAP

The gap, however, is narrowing.

TVS Motor's rise has been driven by a strategy anchored in outpacing industry growth. “We are confident that we will do better than the industry growth, both in domestic and international markets,” Managing Director KN Radhakrishnan said during a recent earnings call.

This outperformance is already visible in retail trends. According to Federation of Automobile Dealers Associations (FADA) data for FY26, TVS grew its retail volumes by 22.49 per cent, way beyond the industry's 13.4 per cent growth.

Its market share rose to 18.89 per cent from 17.49 per cent a year earlier, while Hero MotoCorp's share edged down to 28.4 per cent. The shift is even more visible against Honda — the gap between Honda Motorcycle and Scooter India and TVS narrowed to 6.14 percentage points in FY26 from 7.88 percentage points a year earlier.

PREMIUMISATION

At the core of this momentum is a calibrated shift toward premi-



LUXURY ON WHEELS. TVS Motor's Apache range of feature-rich motorcycles

umisation. The company has leaned into feature-rich motorcycles and scooters such as the Raider, Apache range, Jupiter, and Ntorq.

“Premium and super-premium are growing faster,” Radhakrishnan said. This shift is being validated — and increasingly seen as structural, rather than cyclical.

“Growth is being driven by a richer domestic vehicle mix and higher export volumes,” Axis Securities said in a recent sector note, pointing to improving realisations and stronger product positioning.

Kotak Institutional Equities, in its March quarter earnings preview, endorsed this view and expects this shifting mix to continue driving earnings improvement.

Together, these assessments suggest that TVS Motor's growth is not merely volume-led but increasingly also quality-led — better pricing, stronger mix, and a widening presence in higher-margin segments.

The strategy is also portfolio-led. “We always look at the total portfolio contribution... we don't look segment-wise,” Radhakrishnan said.

A CHANGING DEMAND CYCLE

This positioning is reshaping the domestic market. TVS is capturing urban demand through premium products while riding a rural recovery. FADA data shows rural growth at 13.05 per cent and urban growth at 13.62 per cent in FY26, pointing to a convergence that increasingly favours higher-spec models.

The traditional divide between rural and urban consumption is narrowing, expanding the address-



KN Radhakrishnan, Managing Director, TVS Motor Company

able market for premium offerings.

“With the kind of infrastructure getting built in India... mobility needs... and affordability, I'm a firm believer that 8-9 per cent CAGR is sustainable,” Radhakrishnan said.

EXPORTS POWER GROWTH

International markets are emerging as a key growth engine. TVS has expanded across Africa and Latin America. “The demand in Africa continues to grow... LatAm also has grown,” Radhakrishnan said.

Analysts see exports as both a volume and margin lever. “A higher export mix is supporting margins across auto companies,” Kotak noted, linking international expansion to improved earnings quality.

Yet Southeast Asia remains the toughest market. Indonesia and Vietnam continue to favour Japanese incumbents, making ASEAN the last frontier for Indian OEMs.

THE EV WILD-CARD

Electric mobility could reset the competitive order, but also deter-

Growth of TVS Motor vs industry rivals

Company	Two-wheeler retail volume (in units)		Growth (%)
	FY26	FY25	
TVS Motor	40,46,666	33,03,633	~22.5
Hero MotoCorp	60,83,248	54,46,404	~11.7
Honda	53,61,458	47,91,389	~11.9
Bajaj Auto	22,49,778	21,55,582	~4.4
Overall two-wheeler industry			13.4

Source: Federation of Automobile Dealers Associations

ine whether TVS can translate momentum into leadership.

TVS emerged as the market leader in India's electric two-wheeler segment in FY26, retailing about 341,513 units and capturing a 24 per cent market share, according to FADA data.

The 43.5 per cent year-on-year growth helped it overtake early mover Ola Electric.

Unlike several competitors, TVS has taken a calibrated approach — scaling up through its iQube platform while leveraging its distribution network and brand strength. This has helped it expand beyond early adopters to more mainstream buyers — a shift that has proved challenging for both start-ups and legacy players.

EV penetration is also rising. FADA data shows electric two-wheelers accounted for 6.54 per cent of total volumes in FY26, with monthly penetration nearing double digits.

This positions EVs not just as a new segment but also a structural shift that could reshape market

share over time, potentially accelerating TVS Motor's climb in the domestic hierarchy.

LEGACY STRENGTHS

However, the transition comes with trade-offs. “Margins could be impacted by the margin-dilutive mix of EV scooters,” Axis Securities said, highlighting near-term profitability pressures.

At the same time, Kotak noted that “operating leverage and improved product mix” continue to support margins, suggesting that legacy strengths remain relevant even as EV investments rise.

For TVS, the EV strategy mirrors its broader approach. “Continue to grow the top line... improve the product mix,” Radhakrishnan said.

The challenge will be in converting early leadership into durable scale as the market shifts from subsidy-driven adoption to demand-led growth.

THE ROAD AHEAD

At the premium end, TVS is sharpening its global ambitions through Norton Motorcycles. “We will have a differentiated strategy for Norton,” Radhakrishnan said.

The rise to the global top three marks a coming-of-age moment, but not the endgame.

Closing the gap with Hero at home will test its ability to scale up. Cracking ASEAN will test its global ambition. And making EVs profitable will test its execution discipline.

The climb to third was about momentum. The climb to second will be about execution.

What an Oracle foretells about jobs and careers in the AI era

PEOPLE@WORK



KAMAL KARANTH



THE NEW AI CODE. It may not be curtains yet for software engineering

Knowing what you know now, would you have taken a different career path after college or advised your family and friends to pursue something else altogether? The other day, a former high school classmate called up to ask if his daughter, who wants to pursue computer science engineering, was making the right choice in a world filled with AI noise. I told him I am no oracle on the future of jobs. But if I were him, I would bet on his girl, who was not only a topper in Std XII but also passionate about the subject.

AI-WASHING LAYOFFS

Of late, any enterprise announcing layoffs has an ‘Impacted by AI’ label on it. Though companies like Block, Atlassian and Oracle have their own contexts for layoffs, the media narrative suggests AI impact. We are refusing to acknowledge their declining stock price in the last six months as a larger factor.

It might be worthwhile to share the details surrounding a recent layoff, where I was almost a fly on the wall. In this tech company, the CXO informed his VPs that the global HQ had given him a headcount reduction target. He asked how many full-time employees (FTE) could be laid off? The first solution the VPs offered was, “Can we reduce the number of our contractors?” When reminded that the target was FTEs, each manager came up with a few names. The CXO didn't even ask why those names were picked. There were no discussions on whether AI would replace the laid-off employees. It was redundancy as usual. When I read about this layoff story in the news later, it appeared with an AI flavour.

‘LUMP OF LABOUR’ FALLACY

Significantly, the top 10 AI companies, including OpenAI, Anthropic, and Perplexity, have added 7,500 new employees in the last 12 months. Despite the vibe-coding gains and telling the world to get rid of software engineers, new-age AI companies are adding more engineers themselves. Perhaps we should hold our horses before writing a death sentence on software engineering as a profession. Marc Benioff, founder and CEO of Salesforce, recently said, “Companies are cutting jobs for three very different

reasons: cost that got out of hand; data centre financial commitments; and some genuine AI-driven rebalancing.” Treating them as one story is a mistake.

Marc Andreessen, co-founder of venture capital fund Andreessen Horowitz, has an interesting take. His VC firm has invested not only in some marquee new-age companies like Figma, Databricks, Stripe and Roblox but also GitHub, Airbnb, Twitter, and Pinterest. Despite major bets on the future of AI with companies like OpenAI, Elon Musk's xAI, and Mistral AI, Andreessen recently said most large companies are overstaffed by 25-75 per cent due to excessive pandemic-era hiring and are using AI as a cover to cut jobs. He called it the ‘lump of labour’ fallacy — the mistaken belief that there is a fixed amount of work to be done in an economy, thereby meaning that if one person works more or faster, another works less. It incorrectly assumes that rising automation, immigration, or productivity causes unemployment.

FUTURE TENSE

Unnoticed amid the news of war and AI, mass hiring in the tech sector has seen a structural shift. No longer can we celebrate the hiring of lakhs of engineering students by large tech firms. The numbers have dwindled due to macro-economic conditions, and with the anticipation that AI can do much of the entry-level grunt work. India, though, still holds promise with 100 new global capability centres setting up shop. However, with 2.5 lakh computer science engineers graduating in India each year, the surface area for new tech jobs is shrinking. Going by the recent Claude AI agent source code leak, the roadmap for the three capabilities Claude has lined up as WIP is interesting — proactive mode; dream mode; and autonomous mode, which may bring agentic AI closer to

non-binary human capabilities. According to a Goldman Sachs analysis of 40 years of labour market data, workers who lost jobs due to technological changes saw an average 3 per cent drop in real earnings compared to those displaced by stable roles. In the ten years after losing a job, such workers saw earnings growth that was 10 percentage points lower than those who remained employed. Looks scary?

THE RESET?

A country that exported close to \$300 billion worth of software services last year has been the dream destination for the 8.5 lakh freshly minted engineers each year. This cohort of engineers has mostly chose the IT sector over others like manufacturing, given the salary levels and the sector's continuous growth over the last three decades. From a time when every neighbourhood kid we knew went onsite, to one where someone close to us is getting laid off, the tech reset is hitting hard. Most jobseekers' CVs are now laced with some AI skill; every leader has to have familiarity with OpenClaw and how Claude is simplifying the workflow. It's become tough to differentiate between fluff and reality. All consulting companies are putting out surveys that preach how AI and human beings working together make for a productive workforce.

Suzy Welch's best-selling self-help book *Becoming You* has a take on ‘purpose’. She writes that it requires taking action to “go through the fire” of self-discovery and purposefully constructing the bridge between the life you are currently living and the life you want to live. Let's hope that AI brings the best of us for us and makes it a breakthrough of our lifetime, and not a Kodak moment.

Kamal Karanth is co-founder of Xpheno, a specialist staffing firm

● TABLE TALK

Building Lalit hotels with emotion

Chitra Narayanan

This April, the Lalit Suri Hospitality group embarked on Lalit 2.0, the second such change exercise of the group, says Jyotsna Suri, Chairperson and MD. Launched in 1988 as Bharat Hotels by her late husband, Lalit Suri, the group's first makeover came about after the charismatic founder passed away in 2006 and his wife had to take over the reins. She rebranded the group as The LaLiT in his honour, creating a distinctive identity — the L in the LaLiT logo is designed to resemble the trunk of Lord Ganesha. “We were six hotels then... Today we are 12 hotels, plus two in the mid-segment.”

Explaining the need for the current exercise, Suri says that during the Covid-19 pandemic the group went through a financial crunch and some projects, including an ambitious new hotel in Ahmedabad, were stalled. “We're now in a good position and raring to go forward,” she says.

But why is The LaLiT only at 14 hotels when chains like The Taj, Radisson and Marriott are talking of 500 properties in a few years? “We've never been in the business of growing inventory. In fact, we are very uniquely placed because we own and manage all our hotels,” says Suri.

“We are hoteliers to the core, and we like it like that,” she asserts, although she adds that the group does intend to pick up some management contracts. They would be mid-market, under the Lalit Traveller brand.

I am meeting the dynamic head of the hotel chain, who is also a big force at FICCI (she was president of the chambers in 2015 and now mentors the tourism and culture as well as DEI committees), at The LaLiT on Delhi's Barakhamba Road. But the table across which we are seated is not at any of their famous restaurants — it's in her private office, which is filled with enchanting art-



HOMEGROWN HOTELIER. Jyotsna Suri, Chairperson and MD, Lalit Suri Hospitality group

ILLUSTRATION: PARTHA PRATIM SHARMA

works. Two particularly catch my eye. One is a painting by a Tihar jail inmate (the hotel group had organised an art workshop for the prisoners, which led to this work), and the other is a series of political cartoons by Raj Thackeray.

“I don't like talking and shovelling food at the same time,” Suri says, explaining why we cannot do the usual format of an interview over a meal for this edition of *Table Talk*. Instead, we chat over tea served elegantly with gourmet cookies. Suri says she is only interested in food as fuel, except for Delhi's *chaat*, which she loves.

FRESH DESTINATIONS

While other chains may focus on trending places, The LaLiT has gone to difficult areas, choosing to develop from scratch. Case in point is Bekal, in north Kerala, where it was one of the first to set up a hotel; but the destination took over 15 years to develop as accessibility was an issue. Ditto Khajuraho, where connectivity is still a problem. Or Mangar, an Aravalli wildlands between Faridabad and Gurgaon, where it has set up an eco-friendly resort. In Chitrakoot, Bundelkhand, it is again a pioneer, with a Lalit

Traveller set to come up.

Suri is a quaint mix of pragmatism and emotion. Since her husband died in London, she was determined to have a property in that city; she acquired a former grammar school, St Olave, at a cost of £15 million and turned it into a boutique hotel. “I don't develop hotels because I am adding numbers, but because I want to make a hotel in a particular city,” she says.

As also happened with the hotel in Ahmedabad, which she assures will be ready in time for the Commonwealth Games. “It is on the Sabarmati. It's going to be a beautiful hotel, inspired by Gandhi's era,” she says. “We have always created destinations, not hotels,” she says, explaining that the idea is to play up local festivals and traditions, and invest in cultural rejuvenation. For instance, in Khajuraho, the chain used to organise an annual Shiv Vivah festival to attract tourists. At FICCI, too, she is driving the idea of culture dovetailing into tourism.

An early riser and highly disciplined (she walks 7 km daily and swims regularly), Suri often takes calculated risks — not a surprising trait really, as she comes of entre-

preneurial stock. Her dad moved from Rawalpindi to Delhi during Partition and built a profitable Mercedes-Benz truck business in far-flung Kutch, and was non-conformist enough to send Suri to the co-ed boarding Lawrence School at Sanawar. Apart from giving back to her alma mater, the group runs Step by Step, a well regarded school in NCR, and the Lalit Suri Hospitality School.

Suri has given a free rein to her children to experiment with new ideas. Two daughters, Divya and Deeksha, and son, Keshav, are part of the management; third daughter, Shraddha, runs Subros, the family's auto parts business. Keshav was one of the petitioners against Section 377 and The LaLiT was among the first few hospitality chains to endorse the UN's LGBTQ standards at work.

Asked to list the group's strengths and weaknesses, Suri does it with clinical precision. “Every single hotel of ours has a fabulous location, starting with the hotel we are sitting in... Be it Kashmir, Kolkata, Udaipur, Jaipur, or Mumbai, where we are literally one minute from the airport. Our Kerala hotel sits on an estuary between the sea and a river, and in Khajuraho we are walking distance from a World Heritage Site.”

Next, “We are completely homegrown and deeply rooted in Indian culture. We were the first ones to begin a ‘Namaskar’ tradition of greeting the guest.”

Third, she says, the group is inclusive. “We have about 200 transgenders working for us. We've differently abled people and people from marginalised communities as well,” says Suri.

What about challenges? “We are very cyclical. And affected by external events quickly. When fuel prices go up, we get into trouble; when war breaks out, we get into trouble; during Covid we were in deep trouble. So, we are a very fragile industry. But I won't call it a challenge — it's part and parcel of the industry, and one has to accept it,” she says.

FUND FACTS.

\$1 billion

Nxtra Data Limited received funding from Alpha Wave Global, Bharti Airtel Limited, The Carlyle Group, and Anchorage Capital Partners on March 30, taking the total funding to \$1.241 billion.

\$147 million

Wingify Software Private Limited received funding via rights issue from Everstone Capital Management, Vyom Mankekar, Shivanand Mankekar, Laxmi Mankekar, Kedar Mankekar, and Sparsh Gupta on March 27, taking the total funding to \$147 million.

\$100 million

Sila Solutions Private Limited received funding from Permira on April 8, taking the total funding to \$112 million.

\$40 million

Demifine Fashion Private Limited received Series B funding from Xponentia Capital Partners, Vertex, and Vertex Ventures SE Asia & India on April 1, taking the total funding to \$47 million.

\$22 million

Ctm Labs Private Limited received Series A funding from Greenoaks Capital, RTP Global, and Unicorn India Ventures on April 9, taking the total funding to \$32 million.

Source: PrivateCircle Research, a private market intelligence platform

RE POSTS.

- ✕

You just launched your startup. What do you actually need right now?

 - Users
 - Features
 - Feedback
 - Distribution

Kaitho
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- ✕

AI Startups Replacing Entire Teams With Small Agent Systems
Startups Are Getting Smaller
What used to take 20 people...
Now takes:
- 1 founder
- 5 AI agents
This changes everything about building companies.

Enmanuel Idu
@EnmanuelI82426
- ✕

Build a business, not a startup!
Stand on your feet quickly, instead of finding support - every now and then.

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● LARGE BHASHA MODELS

The chatter-bots speaking up for India

SOUNDS OF DIVERSITY. Voice AI startups are building agentic solutions that can converse in a multitude of regional languages

Sanjana B

In India, the next wave of AI may largely be a chatty affair. As businesses race to replace call centres with intelligent voice agents, startups are building for a uniquely complex market, where scale, language, and latency (delay between input and output) collide.

According to Tracxn data, Indian voice AI startups raised \$160.58 million across 37 funding rounds between 2019 and 2026. Funding peaked in 2023 at \$41.6 million across five rounds, while this year it has so far reached \$30.2 million across three rounds.

Bengaluru-based Gnani.ai, a voice-first agentic AI company, was co-founded in 2016 by Ganesh Gopalan and Ananth Nagaraj. The startup's voice AI platform processes over 30 million spoken interactions daily in over 12 languages, for more than 200 enterprises across sectors including banking, financial services and insurance (BFSI), telecom and automotive, as also government entities. It is also one of the four ventures selected under a government mission for sovereign foundational AI development.

"Our agentic AI platform is designed to handle India-specific nuances like multilingual conversations and turn-taking. We also operate at one of the highest scales worldwide. While it's easy today to deploy a basic voice AI agent, the challenge lies in delivering that at scale — with low latency, high accuracy, and a price point viable for the Indian market. That's where we excel," says Gopalan, who is also the firm's CEO.

The company recently launched Inya VoiceOS, a voice-to-voice model that eliminates the need for intermediate speech-to-text (STT) and text-to-speech (TTS) layers. Currently in a 5B-parameter (a measure of the model's learnability) version, a 14B-parameter upgrade is expected soon. The



Vachana STT and Vachana TTS models offer human-like speech and zero-shot (minimal training) voice cloning capabilities in 12 Indic languages.

Gnani.ai ensures data sovereignty by running all inferences on local data centres. It also has a large proprietary voice dataset.

"We operate across three layers — AI agents tuned to solve specific problems like banking collections, loan disbursement, onboarding, and KYC; an intermediate agent AI layer for partners to build their own agents; and our foundational AI layer, where we provide models such as STT, TTS, and SLMs (small language models) via APIs (application programming interfaces)."

Gnani.ai says its recurring revenue is growing 2-3x annually. It added around 120 customers in the past year and expects to double or triple the count this year. It is also expanding to Japan, the US, and West Asia, while targeting 6-7 verticals by the year-end. Recently, it secured \$10 million Series B investment and plans Series C soon.

DOWN TO DIALECTS

India has over 700 dialects, and most global AI models work well only for English and Hindi. Navana.ai, a voicing AI infrastructure and agent company, addresses this gap by building models from scratch and collecting proprietary data nationwide to enable voice agents at scale.

"We don't just deliver voice agents but also build the underlying models that power them," says Raoul Nanavati, co-founder and CEO of Navana.ai.

The company recently collaborated with IISc, Bangalore, on RESPIN, one of India's largest open source speech datasets, capturing how the country sounds across domains like finance and agriculture. This effort produced over 10,000 hours of audio across nine languages, including 38 dialects.

Navana.ai deploys voice agents for customers who handle inbound and outbound calls, across 22 languages and use cases, with pricing based on per-minute usage.

"We are also looking at sovereign markets outside India with a similar makeup — non-English countries with multiple languages in Southeast Asia, the Middle East, Africa, and parts of Europe," Nanavati says.

To date, Navana.ai has raised \$1.5 million and is currently concluding a Series A round.

"India is voice-first culturally. But for the last decade, digital India has been forced to click, type, and tap. The gap is in capacity and reliability. Businesses cannot put enough humans on the other end of every conversation, across languages, and during peak-hour spikes. Voice AI closes that gap," explains Sneha Roy, co-founder and COO at Murf.AI, a voice AI company founded by IIT-Kharagpur alumni.



Sneha Roy, co-founder and COO of Murf.AI



Raoul Nanavati, co-founder and CEO of Navana.ai



Ganesh Gopalan, co-founder and CEO of Gnani.ai

India's linguistic diversity is the core engineering problem the company is solving for, since many global voice models are not built to handle code-switching efficiently, she says.

Murf.AI offers two core models. Falcon, a real-time TTS engine for voice agents, which supports 35-plus languages and is priced under ₹1 per minute. Falcon encodes phonemes separately from voice, preventing accent carry-over during language switches and preserving native fluency.

The second model, Speech Gen 2, is customised for content creation, with granular control over tone, pacing, and pronunciation for enterprise use.

"Our models are built on ethically sourced speech: consented voice recordings, with voice actors earning royalties every time their voice is chosen," Roy says. The company builds its own proprietary voice models, giving it full control over the architecture.

Murf.AI serves two customer segments: enterprise content teams through Murf Studio, a SaaS platform for voiceovers, e-learning, marketing, and training content; and developers and businesses via the Murf Voice API, built on its Falcon model. It has scaled up to over 195 countries and 10 million users.

Murf.AI has raised \$11.5 million across two funding rounds. It has grown 13x in four years, with ARR now at ₹85-90 crore. The number of paying customers has increased 500 per cent and it is on track to double its revenue, the company says.

Himani Agrawal, COO, Microsoft India and South Asia, observes that since voice systems often operate in regulated environments, handle sensitive data, and interact directly with customers or frontline employees, organisations are increasingly choosing to build in-house AI systems, rather than using standalone tools. "This is a natural progression in AI adoption. As AI moves into mission-critical use, it must be governed, observable, and tightly integrated with existing identity, security, and data frameworks," she says.

"India is a voice-first country. Talking is just more natural here than typing or texting... In B2B, the quantum of business that happens over the phone is staggering — whether it's selling insurance, loans, real estate, or even an FMCG distributor calling retailers to find out the week's needs. All of this is still unscaled and manual, which is where the opportunity lies," says Vardhan Dharmidharka, Principal, Stellaris Venture Partners.

● STARTUPS: VAI-THIE-FUSS

Should founders cash in while the firm is still shaky?



VAITHEESWARAN K

I was one of the judges at a startup pitch event sometime back. One of the key questions entrepreneurs had to answer was, "Why do you want to startup?" Most answers were conventional, such as the desire to create something, work for self, change the world, passionate about starting up, and so on, until a young lady brought the house down by saying, "I want to make lots of money." Beyond the

instant laughter, she raised an important issue: Is it fair for entrepreneurs to sell a part of their shares in a secondary and create some personal wealth, while the startup struggles financially?

Every first-generation startup founder invests a lot of passion and conviction to compensate for low salaries, insanely long hours, relentless pressure and a disproportionate amount of personal risk. Several tiring years later, after perhaps some economic stress at home and watching peers in professional careers getting ahead financially, a thought starts nagging: "When should I look out for myself and consider a secondary?" In simple terms,

selling a slice of personal equity before the firm becomes profitable.

Folks who have never experienced the hardships and challenges of being a first-time founder may think of such an act as questionable, but the reality is a lot more nuanced. Founders are not hermits. Building a startup is not just intellectually demanding but also financially asymmetric. For years, the founder's net worth is trapped in illiquid equity, while others, including employees with ESOP buybacks and investors with portfolio diversification, have some degree of liquidity and protection. To expect founders to take a high moral ground and not take secondaries early is unfair.

Global examples like Travis

Kalanick, Mark Zuckerberg and Brian Chesky, who sold partial stakes in secondaries in Uber, Facebook and AirBnB, respectively, before IPOing, and the Indian examples like Vijay Shekar Sharma and the Bansals executing small secondaries before the PayTM IPO and Walmart's acquisition of Flipkart, respectively, shows that not only are secondaries common but markets also understand them.

Secondaries help entrepreneurs diversify their risks. No one should invest all their money in a single and risky asset, so why should founders? A small nest egg helps founders focus on their startup with renewed energy. A key concern

about founders exiting partially early is that it could reduce their commitment. In startup jargon, this is called "skin in the game". I believe this can cut both ways. A founder who has secured some sort of upside is more likely to stay the course longer. So, the question is not if secondaries are fair. The more important point is the timing. What is the status of the startup when the secondary happens? Is there a context where that is not normal? We will discuss these aspects in the next column.

The writer is a serial entrepreneur and best-selling author of the book 'Failing to Succeed'; posts on X @vaithseek

● CLINICAL INTELLIGENCE

Biotech firm takes the battle to metastasis

Mestastop's platforms find a way to fill a vital gap in cancer treatment

Jyoti Banthia

Bengaluru-based biotech startup Mestastop is preparing to launch a phase II clinical trial aimed at delaying metastasis in colorectal cancer — widely viewed as the biggest gap in oncology care.

While most cancer treatments today focus on shrinking primary tumours, nearly 90 per cent of cancer deaths occur due to metastasis — the spread of cancer cells to new organs. Mestastop founder Arnab Roy Chowdhury says this disconnect in cancer therapeutics drove him to launch the company to build tools that directly target the biology of metastasis.

He points out that conventional oncology has been shaped by the belief that metastasis risk rises with tumour burden, leading to decades of focus on killing fast-growing tumour cells. But the treatments designed to either eliminate tumours or block the movement of cells from the primary site have not halted metastasis.

PREVENTIVE PLATFORM

Mestastop's research came up with a different insight: Only a specific subset of cancer cells can metastasise, and their success is determined not by their ability to escape from the primary tumour but



PREVENTIVE TECH. Arnab Roy Chowdhury, founder of Mestastop

by their ability to adapt and survive in a secondary organ. "Our therapies are focused on preventing this adaptation and stopping the formation of metastatic colonies," he says.

To do this, Mestastop has developed three integrated platforms: METAssay recreates the entire metastasis process on a lab bench, breaking it into 30 steps that reveal the differences in the behaviour of cancer cells and metastasis-prone cells; METSCAN analyses primary tumour cells across these steps and correlates them with long-term clinical outcomes in patients, using machine learning to identify the key events that drive metastatic success — data that can

guide both drug discovery and patient stratification; and METVivo, which speeds up preclinical validation by compressing what traditionally takes four to six months into a six-week, high-throughput animal model.

TRIAL STAGE

The company is moving to clinical trials with two repurposed drugs, originally approved for non-oncology indications, which its platforms flagged as strong anti-metastatic candidates. Retrospective analysis showed that cancer patients who took one of these medicines experienced statistically significant improvements in survival and delayed metastasis. With regulatory requirements completed, Mestastop plans to enrol at least 60 post-surgery colorectal cancer patients into a two-year treatment regimen, with results expected in about three years.

Mestastop's business model centres on licensing its platforms and assets to pharma and biotech partners, earning upfront payments, milestones and royalties. But building a metastasis-focused biotech in India has required patience. "A comparable company globally could raise \$50 million — we've raised \$2 million in seven years," Chowdhury says. Even so, he believes the science will ultimately speak for itself.

Strengthening the hands of agentic AI

bl.interview

Aishwarya Kumar

Artificial intelligence is not just another technology wave, it is also an industrial revolution, says Satyakam Mohanty, co-founder and managing partner of Wyser Capital, on the belief underpinning the venture capital firm's investment thesis. The fund house is betting on enterprise-focused agentic AI startups and companies building AI systems that can move beyond analysis to execution.

With a ₹200-crore fund and investments in startups such as Bizlog, Pype AI, AquaAirX and Bizom, Wyser Capital is looking to back IP-led startups building the next generation of enterprise technology.

Mohanty, who co-founded the firm in 2024 with Suresh Vaswani and Supria Dhanda, discusses with *businessline* how enterprise AI is entering a new phase, how startups can become enterprise-ready, and the structural gaps India must address to build globally competitive AI companies.

Edited excerpts:

Why focus on enterprise agentic AI? Agentic AI represents the next layer of AI adoption. So far, much of the conversation has been about generative AI, systems that can create content or insights. Agentic AI goes further by enabling AI systems to execute tasks and workflows autonomously.

For enterprises, that opens up massive possibilities — from operational automation to improved customer outcomes. We believe this layer will touch almost every



SATYAKAM MOHANTY
Co-founder and managing partner, Wyser Capital

industry, which is why we have focused our investment thesis on it.

What is the fund size and the investment strategy?

We are raising a ₹200-crore fund, including a greenshoe option of about ₹80 crore. Over the next two to three years, we expect to deploy the capital across 25 or more startups.

Our initial cheque sizes range between ₹2 crore and ₹5 crore for seed-stage companies. We also reserve capital for follow-on investments, up to ₹8-10 crore for companies that perform well and continue to scale up.

How do you assess whether an AI

startup is enterprise-ready?

One of the biggest gaps that founders underestimate is enterprise readiness. Solving a problem technically is only the first step. For an enterprise customer to adopt the product, there are multiple layers that need to be in place: security, access control, compliance certifications, and reliability.

Many early-stage founders focus primarily on building the solution. But in enterprise software, those additional layers are critical for adoption.

How quickly can AI startups start generating revenue?

It depends on the type of solution they are building. If it is purely software-based, early proof-of-concept deployments can happen within four to six months, and startups may start generating revenue within six to eight months.

However, if the product involves physical AI systems, such as robotics or hardware integrated with AI, the timeline can extend to two or even three years before meaningful revenue begins.

What are some of the structural gaps in India's AI startup ecosystem?

One key requirement is patient capital. Deep-technology startups take longer to mature compared to traditional SaaS or consumer businesses.

Investors need to evaluate these companies differently — not just based on early revenue numbers but also the underlying technology and its long-term potential.

The second factor is stronger investor-founder collaboration. Beyond capital, startups often need help with enterprise access, global market introductions and product readiness.

DATA BANK.

Repo rate cut transmission to lending and deposit rates

Transmission of the policy rate during the current easing cycle (from February 2025) continued in the second half of the year (H2FY26) — October 2025 to March 2026 — with the softening of both lending and deposit rates, according to the RBI’s latest Monetary Policy Report.

The 25 basis points (bps) policy rate cut in December 2025 had led to a cumulative rate reduction of 125 bps, with the policy repo rate (the interest rate at which the RBI provides liquidity to the banking system to overcome short-term mismatches) currently at 5.25 per cent

The median one-year marginal cost of funds-based lending rate (MCLR) of scheduled commercial banks (SCBs) declined by 20 bps in H2. The weighted average lending rate (WALR) on fresh rupee loans increased by 5 bps during H2 (up to February 2026), mainly reflecting a shift in volume towards sectors attracting higher interest rates, while it declined by 26 bps for outstanding loans.

In the current easing cycle (up to February 2026), the WALR for outstanding loans declined by 87 bps. For fresh rupee loans, the WALR declined by 89 bps.

Interest rate effect
The interest rate effect, a better measure of pricing, declined by 92 bps, reflecting robust passthrough to fresh lending rates. A lower moderation in WALR vis-à-vis the interest rate effect suggests a shift in composition towards higher interest rate loans across banks and sectors

The share of loans linked to the external benchmark-based lending rate (EBLR) in total outstanding floating rate loans of SCBs increased from 62.9 per cent at end-June to 65.4 per cent at end-December 2025.

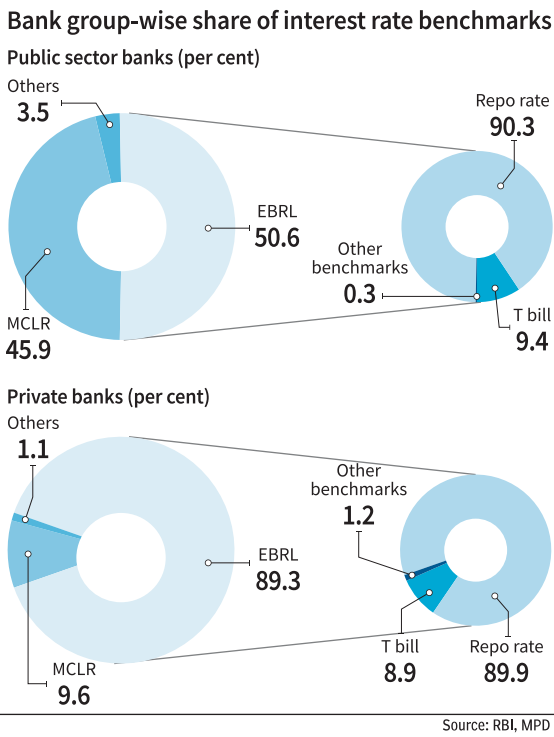
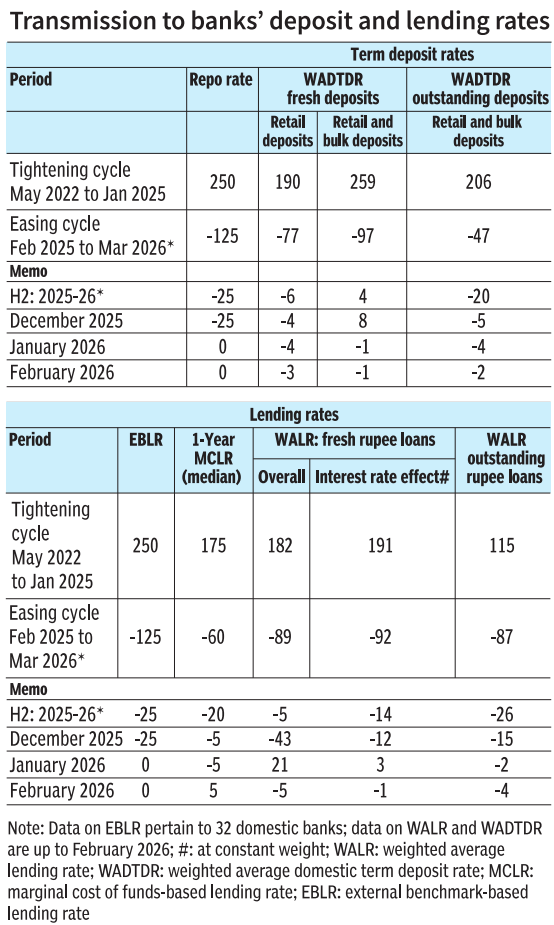
Consequently, the share of MCLR-linked loans declined from 33.8 per cent to 32 per cent over the same period.

Deposit rates
On the deposit side, the weighted average domestic term deposit rate (WADTDR) on outstanding deposits declined by 20 bps in H2 2025-26 (up to February 2026), while it firmed up by 4 bps for fresh deposits.

The combination of sustained credit demand and persistent gap between credit and deposit growth led banks to increase their term deposit rates, especially bulk deposit rates, to bridge the funding gap in recent months.

Transmission to deposit rates has also been robust during the current easing cycle. The WADTDR for fresh and outstanding deposits declined by 97 bps and 47 bps, respectively, during February 2025-26.

The share of low-cost current account and savings account (CASA) deposits declined marginally, although the interest rate on savings deposit (comprising around 30 per cent of total deposits) has also declined to its lowest since its deregulation in June 2025, helping banks protect their net interest margins



● DISTANT RUMBLE

India credit funds shrug off US blues

‘NOT US’. As redemptions roil US credit funds, domestic players insist they are built different and ‘all is well’... for now

Janaki Krishnan

Last month, investors attempting to redeem holdings from Blue Owl Capital — a niche American alternative investment firm — were met with unexpected withdrawal caps.

The move was echoed by industry giants like BlackRock, Apollo, and KKR limiting outflows from their private credit funds.

This wave of restrictions sent chills through the \$3.5 trillion global private credit market, a sector that has boomed since the 2008 financial crisis.

So far, there is no visible stress in India, but global tremors are beginning to unsettle private credit investors backing domestic funds, fueling concerns about potential contagion.

The 13-year-old, \$25-30 billion private credit market in India, still nascent though rapidly growing, is however firm that there is no call for worry since it is different from the US counterpart — from the way it is structured to how it is governed.

“We are not seeing that kind of concern over private credit in India, because people understand it’s very different from the market in the US,” says Kanchan Jain, CEO, Ascertis Credit, an early player in the sector with around \$2 billion deployed across five funds.

In the US, issues such as liquidity mismatches, exposure to software services, leverage, and redemption pressures have created stress, she points out.

In contrast, India’s market is characterised by close-ended funds, lack of leverage, minimal exposure to volatile sectors, and absence of short-term redemption pressures.

THE US SCENARIO
Besides the fact that private credit in the US has grown two rapidly, there are structural issues at play there.

A significant portion of the stress is originating from the tech sector. A high portion of credit has flown into software and SaaS companies at high leverage “with repayment assumptions tied to future valuation rather than current cash flows”. Many of these companies were already making losses at the time of the loans, and the rapid rise of artificial intelligence destroyed many of the assumptions on which the investments were made.

Pranob Gupta, Managing Director, Business Head-India

Alternatives, Lighthouse Canton, a Singapore-headquartered investment firm with \$5 billion of AUM, points out that private credit evolved in the US largely as a substitute for leveraged finance, supported by years of ultra-low interest rates and abundant liquidity

The redemption pressure from investors is stemming from structural issues rather than asset quality concerns. The funds facing the pressure are typically open-ended or evergreen funds that offer periodic liquidity.

“In many US funds, investors have the ability to exit the fund... the ability to push the button to exit has basically crept into their system,” says Priyam Kedia, Senior Fund Manager, Vivriti Asset Management, a mid-market private credit player with an asset book size exceeding ₹4,500 crore.

The high leverage in the US, often at 5-6x of debt-to-EBITDA, combined with rising retail participation and the dominance of financial sponsors such as private equity, has complicated the stress situation, Kedia adds.

Companies in the US first approach the banking system for funds, then access the bond markets and, once both those limits are exhausted, they turn to private credit.

“So for a US company or a private credit entering any

SNAPSHOT OF THE PRIVATE FUNDING UNIVERSE

Size of global private credit market: **\$3.5 trillion**

US private credit market: **\$2.5 trillion**

Indian private credit market: **\$25-30 billion**

EVENTS UNFOLDING IN THE US PRIVATE CREDIT SECTOR

- Rising rates expose vulnerabilities:** The sharp increase in interest rates reveals structural weaknesses, especially for borrowers who took on floating-rate debt during the low-rate era.
- Borrowers under severe stress:** Interest payments for many companies have doubled or even tripled, putting significant pressure on highly leveraged firms.
- Refinancing risks intensify:** Weakening earnings visibility among borrowers makes refinancing more difficult, increasing the risk of defaults.
- Lenders turn cautious:** Major institutions like JPMorgan have marked down exposures — particularly in software-linked loans — signalling a shift to a more defensive lending stance.

WHERE INDIA’S PRIVATE CREDIT MARKET STANDS

- Still at an early stage:** Private credit in India accounts for just 0.6 per cent of GDP, \$25–30 billion in AUM, and barely 1 per cent of total bank credit
- Focused on niche uses:** Private credit is largely used for acquisition financing, capex funding, refinancing, promoter financing, and complex structured deals.
- Aids capital market growth:** It helps diversify investor portfolios beyond equities and real estate, improving capital allocation and reducing concentration of risks.
- Strong regulatory framework:** The market operates mainly through SEBI-regulated Category II AIFs, with strict disclosure norms and valuation requirements.

No leverage-driven systemic risk: Category I and II AIFs are prohibited from taking long-term leverage, limiting the risk of contagion to the broader financial system.

company, the starting leverage is very high,” he says.

The growing reliance on bank-provided leverage has added to the brewing crisis.

Additional borrowing through NAV facilities or repo lines can push the effective leverage to 7–8x, says Lighthouse Canton in a note on the emerging problems.

This layered leverage is often not fully visible to investors and creates systemic risk. As credit conditions tighten, banks may withdraw or reduce these lines, forcing asset sales at distressed valuations, it adds.

IMMUNE SO FAR
India’s private credit market is structurally more conservative. High domestic interest rates limit excessive leverage, and sectors such as IT services do not typically rely on leveraged buyouts.

Additionally, underwriting standards, including collateral and covenant protections, are tighter in India than in developed markets.

“Indian companies are not that heavily leveraged compared to their peers in the US. So, I don’t think this is an asset-class risk as such, or that the whole private credit space is headed in a dangerous direction,” says Rajeev Vidhani, Partner at Khaitan & Co.

In India, funds are largely close-ended — Category II al-

ternative investment funds (AIFs) — eliminating liquidity pressures from investor redemptions, Kedia points out.

“The leverages are closer to 3–3.5x as compared to 5–6x in the US. Indian private credit lends not because leverage is high, but because the banking system is not able to fund due to RBI restrictions,” he says.

India also remains a promoter-driven market, where promoters can inject capital as an additional buffer during a period of stress.

Regulatory oversight also plays a key role, says Lighthouse Canton’s Gupta.

The Securities and Exchange Board of India keeps a strict eye on activities, particularly around Category II AIFs, helping curb excessive risk-taking. In the US, however, regulators have flagged issues such as valuation inconsistencies and risk migration.

Another advantage in India is that credit portfolios are predominantly linked to domestic assets — such as infrastructure, power, and local manufacturing — which have limited exposure to global disruptions or technology-led risks.

Vivriti, for instance, is focused on domestic-facing sectors such as steel, cement, auto components, and pharma. The firm has avoided new-age, asset-light, and venture debt exposures, prioritising resilience over rapid growth.

While Jain did not disclose Ascertis’ portfolio exposure, the firm has lent to Veranda Learning, mPokket Financial Services, and a roads EPC company.

The real estate sector is a disproportionately big recipient of private credit; there is also significant exposure to health-care, industrial products, logistics and education. The growing participation of large corporate houses with strong balance sheets and steady cash flows — such as Reliance Industries, Embassy Group, and PharmEasy — underscores the rising appeal of the private credit market, while also indicating a relatively low risk of default.

There is little evidence to suggest that fund managers are significantly altering core deal structures such as covenants or collateral. Instead, they are enhancing due diligence by incorporating additional risk factors — such as exposure to global markets, sensitivity to fuel costs, and supply chain dependencies — into underwriting decisions. “This reflects adaptive analysis rather than tightening of standards,” says Jain.

As of now, the returns and exit timelines also remain unchanged. Unlike in private equity, where exits depend on market conditions and IPOs, private credit investments rely on contractual cash flows and scheduled amortisation, leaving them less vulnerable to market volatility. In fact, periods of uncertainty may create more opportunities for private credit, as companies seek structured financing solutions.

CAUTION AHEAD
However, the war in West Asia, leading to rising energy costs and disruptions in supply chain, is having an impact on several industry sectors.

Some degree of stress is inevitable. Rising input costs and supply chain bottlenecks may affect borrower cash flows in the short term, says Gupta, adding, “If the market was cautious earlier, it should now be doubly cautious — but for sophisticated investors, this phase also presents an opportunity to secure better terms.”

Vivriti’s Kedia advocates active monitoring and case-by-case responses to stress.

“Now some industries will be more affected than others. So obviously one will have to see how much margin is available,” says Vidhani.

“I think great fund managers with a proven track record will continue to be trusted and will be able to raise funds,” he adds.

Banking on deposit tokens and tokenisation

As global finance evolves rapidly, banks in India look for ways to accelerate modernisation without compromising stability



AISHWARY GUPTA

India stands at a pivotal moment in the evolution of its financial system. Over the last decade, public digital infrastructure such as UPI and Aadhaar have transformed how money moves domestically. Yet, as global finance shifts toward programmable, always-on settlement rails, India faces a strategic question: how does it modernise banking without compromising stability?

Two ideas — deposit tokens and asset tokenisation — may hold the answer.

Deposit tokens represent a natural evolution of bank money. Issued by regulated banks on secure, permissioned blockchain rails, these tokens are fully backed by traditional deposits and subject to prudential oversight. Each token is a direct claim on a bank’s balance sheet, preserving trust while unlocking new technical capabilities. Rather than operating outside the system, deposit tokens extend the regulated banking framework into a programmable digital layer.

This distinction is critical. Much of the debate around digital money has focused on the perceived trade-offs between innovation and safety. Deposit tokens eliminate this false choice. They enable near instant settlement, atomic deliv-



ISTOCK

ery versus payment, and automated reconciliation. These are features that require multiple intermediaries and delayed clearing, without introducing new credit or liquidity risks.

For Indian banks, the implications are immediate. Interbank settlements, treasury operations, and large-value corporate payments can move from batch-based processes to real-time rails. Cross-border transactions, which today remain slow, expensive, and opaque, can be sped up with greater transparency, and compliance embedded directly in transactions rather than applied after the fact.

Several global blockchain infrastructure providers, including Polygon, are working with banks and other institutions on permissioned, compliance-first blockchain rails for tokenised

deposits and real-world assets.

Tokenisation of real-world assets presents an equally important opportunity. India is rich in assets but constrained by liquidity. Vast amounts of capital remain locked in real estate, gold, infrastructure, and unlisted equity. These valuable assets are difficult to divide, transfer, or use efficiently as collateral. Tokenisation represents ownership or economic rights as digital tokens that can be fractionalised, transferred, and settled with far lower friction.

SIMPLE, TRANSPARENT
In real estate, tokenisation can simplify complex ownership structures with greater transparency. Gold, long an asset of choice for Indian households, can be tokenised with secure custody and instant settlement, allowing it to integrate

effectively with formal financial markets. Even private equity and venture investments, traditionally illiquid and limited to institutional players, can benefit from controlled liquidity under compliant tokenised frameworks.

Importantly, tokenisation is not about speculative financialisation. It is about making existing value more efficient, reducing operational costs, improving access, and widening participation under clear regulatory guardrails. When paired with bank-issued deposit tokens, tokenised assets can settle instantly in regulated digital money, reducing counterparty risk and enabling new market structures.

Technology, however, is only part of the equation. For India to remain competitive, regulatory clarity — particularly around foreign exchange, AML and KYC, and cross-border use of blockchain-based instruments — is essential. Many tokenisation initiatives are today confined to domestic pilots or sandbox environments due to the uncertainty around capital controls, custody norms, and cross-jurisdictional compliance.

This is where India has a strategic advantage. By proactively defining how regulated digital money and tokenised assets can operate across borders — especially for trade finance, remittances, and institutional settlements — India can help shape global standards rather than adapt to them later. Other financial centres are already in-

tegrating blockchain rails into mainstream banking while preserving regulatory oversight. Falling behind would be not just a technological failure, but also a strategic one.

The cost of inaction is subtle but real. Global finance is being built on programmable infrastructure, where money, assets, and compliance move together. If Indian banks and institutions cannot participate in these networks, capital and innovation will naturally gravitate toward jurisdictions that can. Over time, this risks diminishing India’s influence in global financial markets.

Deposit tokens and tokenisation do not represent a break from India’s banking model. They are evolutionary steps, extending trust, regulation, and scale into a new technological paradigm. Much like UPI modernised payments while remaining invisible to users, these instruments can quietly upgrade the financial backbone of the economy.

India has already demonstrated its ability in building digital public infrastructure at a population scale. The next trillion dollars of value will depend on whether the same clarity and ambition are applied to the banking layer itself. The cross-roads is here, and the direction India chooses will shape not just its financial system but also its role in the future of global finance.

The writer is Global Head of Payments at Polygon Labs

Tiger Global reassessment back on table; GAAR relief won't impact SC tax ruling

WAY FORWARD. Verdict allows I-T Dept to proceed with recovery of capital gains tax linked to the fund's estimated gains of over ₹14,500 cr

Shishir Sinha
New Delhi

With the Supreme Court ruling against Tiger Global clearing the way for tax recovery, the Income Tax Department is set to resume reassessment proceedings against the US-based fund, signalling that the recent GAAR rule amendments do not dilute the impact of the judgment.

Tax officials said the March 31 notification issued by the Central Board of Direct Taxes (CBDT), which protects legacy investments made before April 1, 2017, from the ambit of the General Anti-Avoidance Rules (GAAR), does not alter the position in the Tiger Global case.

GAAR empowers tax authorities to deny tax benefits

arising from arrangements primarily designed to avoid taxes, even if they comply with the letter of the law.

"The notification is not about any specific case. Since the Supreme Court has ruled in favour of the department in the Tiger Global case, proceedings will continue as per law," a senior official said, adding that reassessment is expected to be completed soon.

LEGACY INVESTMENTS
The clarification comes after uncertainty emerged over whether the GAAR amendments, which were widely seen as restoring tax certainty for legacy investments, would affect the Tiger Global dispute.

Officials indicated that recovery may not be limited to the refund already withheld, and additional tax demands

AMOUNT WITHHELD

- Tiger Global International II Holdings 2018-19 (₹866.91 cr)
- Tiger Global International III Holdings 2018-19 (₹95.19 cr)
- Tiger Global International IV Holdings 2018-19 (₹5.42 cr)
- Total: ₹967.52 cr



could arise following reassessment. When asked specifically whether there would be a demand for an amount over and above the refund withheld, an IT official, who did not wish to be named, did not rule out that possibility. Also, he reiterated that all tax disputes cannot be labelled as overreach or 'tax terrorism'.

"Many disputes arise from genuine differences of interpretation in evolving areas of

law. Final certainty emerges only when the highest court settles the issue," the official told *businessline*.

On March 31, the CBDT amended Income Tax Rules to explicitly provide that income arising from the transfer of investments made before April 1, 2017, will not be subjected to GAAR, even if exits occur after that date.

The move was aimed at ring-fencing legacy private equity and hedge fund in-

vestments and reassuring foreign investors after the Supreme Court's January ruling. In its judgment, the Supreme Court had held that Tiger Global's gains from the 2018 sale of its stake in Flipkart were taxable in India, ruling that the transaction constituted an impermissible tax avoidance arrangement and therefore did not qualify for treaty benefits under the India-Mauritius Double Taxation Avoidance Agreement. The ruling effectively allowed the tax department to proceed with recovery of capital gains tax linked to the fund's estimated gains of over ₹14,500 crore.

Tiger Global had claimed exemption under grandfathering provisions and sought a refund of ₹967.52 crore for assessment year 2019-20, which was withheld by the

tax department. While the Delhi High Court had earlier granted relief to the fund, the Supreme Court reversed that decision, holding that GAAR provisions were applicable.

CLEAR DISTINCTION

The government, however, has sought to draw a clear distinction between the Tiger Global ruling and the broader relief provided to legacy investors. While the Supreme Court judgment underscores GAAR's applicability to arrangements lacking commercial substance, the amended rules are intended to protect genuine pre-April 1, 2017 investments from retrospective tax exposure, which offers reassurance to long-term offshore investors even as enforcement proceeds in the Tiger Global case.

Asha Bhosle, timeless voice of a thousand moods falls silent

Janaki Krishnan
Mumbai

Abhi na jao chod kar, ke dil abhi bharaa nahi

This duet with Mohammed Rafi from *Hum Dono* is probably playing in the hearts of billions of fans of Asha Bhosle, whose voice was silenced forever, as she passed away on Sunday at the age of 92 in Breach Candy Hospital, Mumbai.

OBITUARY.

For more than seven decades, Asha Bhosle's voice has captured the many moods of a nation discovering itself through songs — playful, sensuous, tender and timeless.

ASTONISHING RANGE

Bhosle's voice had an astonishing range and versatility navigating nightclub cabaret numbers, ghazals and classical compositions with equal ease.

She had the ability to use her voice to conjure up the mood and scene for listeners, whether it was the teasing *Aaiye Meherban* (*Howrah Bridge*), the effervescent *Piya tu ab to aaja*, the swinging *Dum maro dum*, the soulful, *Dil cheez kya hai* from *Umrao Jaan*, or the melancholic *Mera kuch samaan* from *Ijaazat*, for the last two of which she won the National Award.

Bhosle's early singing years were spent under the shadow of her older sister Lata Mangeshkar. She also modelled herself on Geeta Dutt, who had a distinctive smoky voice, but later developed her own style.

When she was 16, she eloped with and married Ganpatrao Bhosle, who was twice her age, though her family was opposed to it. She separated from him in 1960 and later married RD Burman in



Asha Bhosle (1933-2026)

1980. Bhosle made her debut in singing with the Marathi song *Chala chala nav bala in Majha Bal* at the age of 10 and her first Hindi film song was *Saawan Aaya in Chunariya*. Her first major song that earned her popularity was *Nanhe munne bacche* from Raj Kapoor's *Boot Polish*.

Music composer OP Nayyar was instrumental in giving Bhosle her identity and has often said that he preferred her 'individualistic' style to that of her sister. They collaborated to produce hits such as *Aao Huzoor Tumko* and *Chain se humko kabhi*. She also collaborated with British pop star Boy George, REM frontman Michael Stipe and several others.

She won nominations for two Grammy's, and won the Dada Saheb Phalke Award and Padma Vibhushan.

Every admirer of her songs would have their own Asha Bhosle-moments.

I remember an overnight bus journey from Delhi to Manali many years ago — long, uncomfortable and exhausting. In the early hours of the morning, as the bus pulled over for a brief halt, we heard it: faint, yet unmistakable — the strains of *Chura liya hai*, drifting in from what must have been a distant radio. In that moment, silence fell over the bus. Every passenger listened, as if held by the same spell. The fatigue seemed to lift, as though the music had breathed life back into all of us.

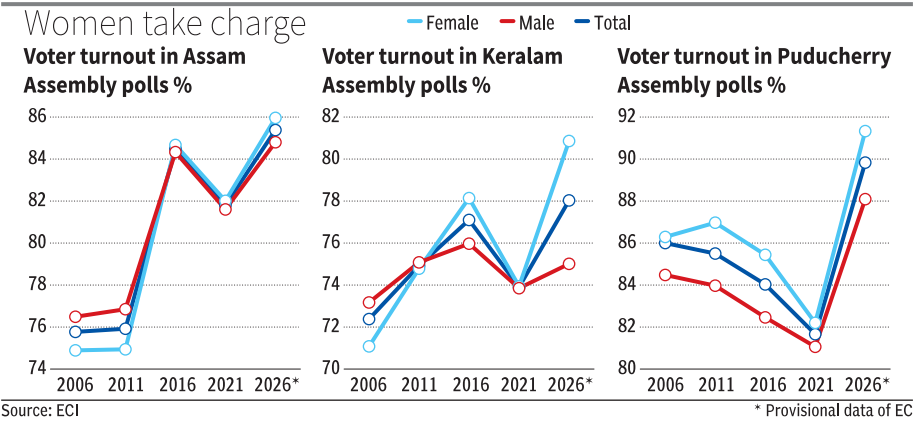
Women voters power high turnouts in Assembly elections

Sindhu Hariharan
Chennai

As Assam, Puducherry and Kerala displayed high voter enthusiasm and record-high turnout last week, data show that women voters were key drivers of this. The women voter turnout from the 2021 to 2026 polls jumped up at rates higher than the overall turnout increase across all three states.

DATA FOCUS.

A huge 91.3 per cent of the female electorate in Puducherry, 86 per cent in Assam, and 80.9 per cent in Kerala voted in the Assembly polls on Thursday. In comparison, the male voter turnout was 88.1



per cent in Puducherry, 84.8 per cent in Assam, and 75 per cent in Kerala.

From 2021 to the 2026 polls, the highest jump in the women turnout was seen at Puducherry — a 9 percentage point jump compared to an 8.1

percentage point spike in total turnout. This increase was 6.9 per cent points in Kerala (total 4.13), and 3.95 per cent points (total 3.58) in Assam.

Political observers say this is likely driven by the growing women-centric welfare meas-

ures across states that create a direct state-citizen link with the demographic. This influences women's autonomy as voters, instead of voting how the male members of the family do. Additionally, Puducherry also has the Vijay factor,

they add, with his rallies seeing strong women presence. Afroz Alam, head of the Department of Political Science at the Maulana Azad National Urdu University, said high voter turnout in general could be either a popular mandate for the incumbent or a wave of anti-incumbency.

This year, the SIR drive has also helped reach out and create a charged atmosphere among voters to come exercise their rights, he added.

THE VIJAY EFFECT

As for women turnout, he believes that political parties have "appealed to the political consciousness of women" and "sharpened their political agency" with welfare measures specifically directed at them.

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